

F1.3 How histories get written: canons, periods, the timeline as an argument; design history versus design studies

Every design timeline makes an argument about who counts, and someone made it at a known date. The learner learns to read a canon, a period and a civilisation label as claims by a source, and to annotate what they leave out.

Spec

Row	F1.3
Essential question	Who decided where design history starts, how it is cut into periods, and who is in it?
Opening move	Argument first (form 13). Claim: "A timeline just puts things in order." Counter-claim: "A timeline is an argument. Its start, its breaks and its names were chosen by someone." Case: the word "civilisation". Its earliest known French use is by the marquis de Mirabeau (1756–57; sources differ), and it was set against "barbarism". In 1919 the Privy Council, deciding land in Southern Rhodesia, wrote that "some tribes are so low in the scale of social organization" that their rights could not be recognised. In 1992 the High Court of Australia (Mabo) quoted that line and called the theory "false in fact". The learner picks a side before scrolling. The card returns at the end.

Row	F1.3
Lab or main interactive	Timeline scrub (form 11), "The canonical line". A default design-history line runs from Vasari's <i>Lives</i> (1550) through the academies and the Salon to the Bauhaus. Three lenses sit over it. Who defined it: each band carries "as defined by [source, date]", on PeriodO's model. What the record holds: a strip under the line shows open (CC0) record counts by region. Labels: civilisation names open onto groupings and are never ranked; no rise-and-fall curves. A second track scrubs Thomsen's Stone, Bronze and Iron Ages across regions (PRD070, PRD018, PRD045, PRD170). The ages arrive in different orders, or not at all. The three cases are stops on the line. Timing: opening 5 min, scrub 12, concept 8, cases 12, apply 10, Mirror 3.
Concept	About 650 words, in five short parts. (1) Canon: a list of named makers that sets a standard (Vasari; Pevsner as a later example). (2) Hierarchy of the arts: academies (Florence 1563, Paris 1648, London 1768) and the Salon split "fine" art from "decorative" or "applied" work; craft, art and design became ranks, not only kinds. (3) Periods: a period is a definition by a source with a place and dates. Thomsen's three ages were built on Danish collections and are always regional. (4) Civilisation as an argument: Mirabeau to Childe's criteria, which later readers turned into a test; Toynbee and Huntington as historiography; Graeber and Wengrow (2021) against a single path of stages. F1's rule: civilisation is a search label, never ranked. (5) Design history versus design studies: Margolin (1992) and Forty (1993). A closing note: adding more cases to a canon (pluralism) is not decolonisation (Decolonising Design, 2019).

Row	F1.3
Cases	Three, each an object story on the line. (a) Vasari's <i>Lives and the academy</i> (F1.11): the 1568 edition with woodcut portraits, Met 358298. (b) Great Zimbabwe and the myth (F1.6): a site plan in J. Theodore Bent's <i>The Ruined Cities of Mashonaland</i> (1892), which credited "a Semitic race", and the Rhodesian censorship of the 1970s. (c) "Islamic art" as a collectors' category (F1.10, F1.12a): a page copied by the calligrapher Sultan 'Ali al-Mashhadi in Herat, late 15th century, Met 446169.
Apply — maker	Annotate a canonical timeline (the default line, or one in a design book you own). Add five notes: one region it leaves out; one kind of maker it leaves out (unnamed, women, guild, enslaved); one period label rewritten as "X, as defined by Y (date)"; one open-record object the line cannot hold; one thing the record itself cannot show (not collected, not public domain). Save to SRC.
Apply — briefer	Annotate a "history of our category" timeline from a pitch, brand deck or brief (sample provided). Add the same five notes. Then write one clause for a brief, e.g. "Any timeline we publish names who defined each period and which regions it leaves out." Save the notes to SRC and the clause to CMB.
Partner	The Mirror. It reflects the learner's own choices back. Question: "Your line starts at [the learner's start date]. Who taught you to start there?" It counts the regions in the learner's notes. It says if all five notes add cases and none changes the frame. It flags any ranking of civilisations. Test: the learner rewrites one of their own labels as a definition by a source. Then they name one thing their own annotation still leaves out.
Forms	13 (argument card), 11 (timeline scrub).

Row	F1.3
Consumption forms	Five-minute: the argument card and case (b). Session: the full unit, about 50 minutes. Reference: four Atlas cards (civilisation as an argument; the biases of the record; the hierarchy of the arts; Margolin and Forty) and the annotated line.
Media	Open museum records (Met public domain, Cleveland CC0); a public-domain book plan (Project Gutenberg); our own diagrams and maps; link-outs (AIC kente record, UNESCO decision, the Mabo judgment).
Artifact fields	SRC (main); CMB (briefer clause).
Threads	Attribution and Authority (canons, named makers); Writing and Argument (argument card, annotation); Accessibility level 1 (the scrub works by keyboard and has a text-table version of every band).
Closing contribution	SRC line: "My timeline source is [title, author, date]; it starts at [X], defined by [source]; it leaves out [Y]; my period labels are definitions by [sources]."
Claims sheet	20 claims, section 3.

1. Responsibility block

The unit must reach these canon rows:

- **Labels and schemes:** CIV085 "Western", CIV086 "Islamic", CIV005 Great Zimbabwe (as a label), POL015, PLC087.
- **Historiographers:** PER395 Vasari, PER459 Childe, PER460 Toynbee, PER461 Huntington, PER468 Graeber, PER469 Wengrow, PER474 Margolin, PER475 Forty, PER471 Pevsner (as a named canon only).
- **Academies and hierarchy:** INS049 Accademia delle Arti del Disegno, GAP075 Académie royale, GAP074 Royal Academy, GAP084 Salon, GAP019 Academic art, MKR064 Guild of Saint Luke.
- **Periods:** PRD070 three-age system, PRD018 Later Stone Age (Africa), PRD045 Iron Age (Levant), PRD057 Early Iron Age (Greece), PRD170 Late Bronze Age (steppe).

- **Critique and text:** MOV052 Decolonising design, TXT005 *Le vite*.
- **Object types:** the printed book, the calligraphy folio, the site plan.
- **Sub-regions:** EU-WCE, AF-SOU, AS-CEN (SCH019 Herat school), OC-AUS (Mabo, through the opening), WA-LEV and the steppe (through the scrub).

The Atlas carries the rest as linked cards:

- **Civilisation labels:** the other CIV rows, as search labels.
- **Asante goldweights re-read:** COM030, POL029, STY088, OBT164; Cleveland 1962.244 and 1935.306.
- **Kente and the record:** PRA002, MKR003, AIC 65187.
- **Great Zimbabwe birds:** OCC169 (sacred; not shown here).
- **Asante regalia:** OCC155, OCC292.
- **Other units:** F1.30 owns calendars and periodisation in depth. F1.19b (the designer as a profession, proposed) is paired with the hierarchy-of-the-arts part.

World chapters reached (seven):

- F1.11 Europe: case (a).
- F1.6 Africa: case (b), plus the goldweights and kente link.
- F1.10 Islamic world: case (c).
- F1.12a Steppe and Central Asia: case (c) Herat, plus PRD170 on the scrub.
- F1.12 Australia and the Pacific: Mabo, in the opening.
- F1.9a West Asia before Islam: PRD045 on the scrub.
- F1.8 East Asia: CIV045, Huntington's "Japanese civilisation" as an example of a bloc label.

2. Protocol screen

- **Great Zimbabwe:** the soapstone birds are sacred (CIV005, OCC169), and the 2026 return included ancestral human remains. Show neither. From Bent's book, use only the site plan. Exclude his plates of the birds and his photographs of living people. Put Bent's terms in quotation marks and attribute them.
- **Mabo:** add a Notice on Meriam and all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander material. Show no images of people. Add a content note on the dispossession language in the 1919 quotation.
- **Kente and goldweights (Atlas link):** add a Notice for Asante and Ewe weavers and Akan casters. Never show the Golden Stool. Describe a UNESCO element as Ghana's account of the practice.

- **Calligraphy folio:** it holds poetry by Sa'di, not scripture. No content note is needed. Confirm that before build.
- **People as goods:** Asante and colonial contexts mention enslaved people. Always write "enslaved people", never goods or cargo.

3. Claims (20)

1. The earliest known French use of "civilisation" is by Mirabeau in *L'Ami des hommes*. Larousse dates it 1756; Wikipedia says 1757. — documented (the date is contested; give both). — <https://www.larousse.fr/encyclopedie/divers/civilisation/34231>; <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Civilization> — summary.
2. The word stood for progress and was "opposed to barbarism or rudeness". — documented. — <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Civilization> — summary.
3. In Mabo (No 2), 1992, Brennan J quoted the 1919 Privy Council: "Some tribes are so low in the scale of social organization...". He called that basis "false in fact and unacceptable in our society". — documented. — [https://alor.org/Storage/Library/Mabo%20v%20Queensland%20\[No%202\].html](https://alor.org/Storage/Library/Mabo%20v%20Queensland%20[No%202].html) — full text (an unofficial mirror; AustLII returned 403).
4. Childe's 1950 *Town Planning Review* article set out a ten-point model of the "urban revolution". — documented. That later readers used the list as a test for "civilisation" is interpretive (our framing). — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Urban_revolution — summary.
5. Toynbee's *A Study of History* traced the rise and, mostly, decline of 21 civilisations. Huntington argued the 21st century would see a "clash of civilizations". — documented. The canon row says "some two dozen"; align it. — <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Civilization> — summary.
6. Graeber and Wengrow (2021) argue that people tried many social forms rather than passing through fixed stages. — documented as their argument. Two readings: supporters take it as a break with stage models; one reviewer calls it "a very defensible argument already made several times". The brief's wording "no single original form" is not verified verbatim; a review quotes "no 'original' form of human society". — <https://www.sapiens.org/culture/dawn-of-everything-excerpt/> (excerpt); <https://notevenpast.org/a-false-dawn/> (review) — partial text.
7. Thomsen named the Stone, Bronze and Iron Ages while arranging Denmark's national collection. He published the scheme in *Ledetraad til nordisk Oldkyndighed* (1836). — documented. — <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Christian-Jurgensen-Thomsen> — summary.

8. For PeriodO, a period needs a name, time bounds, a region and "some citable source". An authority is "a set of periods that share a source". — documented. — <https://perio.do/technical-overview/> — full text.
9. The Met holds the 1568 edition of Vasari's *Le vite* with woodcut illustrations, catalogued as public domain. — documented. — <https://collectionapi.metmuseum.org/public/collection/v1/objects/358298> — full record.
10. The Florentine Academy of Design was founded in 1563 by Cosimo I, "at the instigation of" Vasari, and set "in contrast to the guilds". — documented. — <https://www.britannica.com/place/Academy-of-Design> — summary.
11. The French and English royal academies were founded in 1648 and 1768. From the late 18th century they had "a virtual monopoly" on taste and official patronage. — documented. — <https://www.metmuseum.org/essays/the-salon-and-the-royal-academy-in-the-nineteenth-century> — full essay (Rosenfeld, 2004).
12. The Royal Academy's 36 founders included two women, Mary Moser and Angelica Kauffman. The next woman became a full Academician in 1936. — documented. — <https://www.royalacademy.org.uk/page/a-brief-history-of-the-ra> — full page.
13. Kristeller (1951) called Batteux's 1746 treatise "the decisive step" towards the system of the fine arts. — interpretive (a scholar's thesis). — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Charles_Batteux — summary.
14. In 1892 Bent concluded that Great Zimbabwe's builders were "of a Semitic race and of Arabian origin". — documented. — <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/69067/69067-h/69067-h.htm> — full text.
15. Randall-MacIver (1906) and Caton-Thompson (1929) found Great Zimbabwe to be African work; Randall-MacIver named the ancestors of the Shona. In the 1970s Rhodesia censored guidebooks and museum displays about it, and Garlake was forced to leave in 1970. — documented. — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Great_Zimbabwe; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Peter_Garlake — summary (citing Sinclair and De Baets); also CL-134.
16. Blair and Bloom (2003) call a distinct "Islamic" art tradition "a product of late nineteenth- and twentieth-century Western scholarship". They add that much of it was not made by Muslims for the faith. — interpretive (a scholarly position, widely cited). — <https://www.collegeart.org/pdf/artbulletin/Art%20Bulletin%20Vol%2085%20No%201%20Blair%20and%20Bloom.pdf> — full text.

17. The 1910 Munich exhibition showed about 3,600 objects from more than 260 collections. It raised things once seen as "folk art or arts and crafts" to "masterpieces". The Met's 1930 handbook still said "Mohammedan Decorative Arts". — documented. — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Meisterwerke_muhammedanischer_Kunst (summary); <https://www.metmuseum.org/met-publications/a-handbook-of-mohammedan-decorative-arts> (publisher page).
18. Margolin (*Design Studies*, 1992) proposed folding design history into design studies. Forty replied in the *Journal of Design History* (1993), and *Design Issues* ran a special issue in 1995. — documented. — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Design_studies — summary.
19. The Decolonising Design manifesto (Abdulla, Ansari and others, 2019) says "It is not sufficient for design institutions to simply include a greater diversity of actors or perspectives." — documented. — <https://jfsdigital.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/12-Ansari-Decolonising-Design.pdf> — full text.
20. The record is uneven. Cleveland's CC0 set held 42,316 records on 29 Sept 2026: 2,544 in Chinese Art, 388 in African Art and 294 in Islamic Art; a keyword search for "Oceania" gave 112. The AIC Asante kente wrapper (1901/50) is flagged "not public domain". Ghana, as State Party, nominated Kente to UNESCO in 2024. — documented (the counts are a snapshot). "The record is biased" is interpretive. — <https://openaccess-api.clevelandart.org/api/artworks/?cc0=1&limit=1>; <https://api.artic.edu/api/v1/artworks/65187>; <https://ich.unesco.org/en/decisions/19.COM/7.B.38> — full records.

Unit framing (interpretive): a timeline is an argument by a source; civilisation is a search label, never a rank. Cleveland's Islamic count does not show the "strong on the Islamic world" pattern that the decided addition states. That pattern may hold for the Met; a checker must confirm it before the claim is written.

4. Nodes

- **Opening:** CIV085, CIV086. Propose new rows: *Victor de Riqueti, marquis de Mirabeau* (person); *L'Ami des hommes* (primary text); *In re Southern Rhodesia* (1919) (event); *Mabo v Queensland (No 2)* (1992) (event).
- **Scrub:** PRD070, PRD018, PRD045, PRD057, PRD170, CIV045, PER459–461, PER468–469. Propose: *PeriodO* (institution/resource); *Childe, "The Urban Revolution" (1950)* (primary text); *Thomsen, Ledetraad (1836)* (primary text).
- **Case (a):** PER395, TXT005, INS049, GAP075, GAP074, GAP084, GAP019, MKR064, PER471. Propose: *Charles Batteux* (person); *"Fine arts" versus "decorative/applied arts"* (idea row, THEME).

- **Case (b):** CIV005, POL015, PLC087, ARC041, CL-133, CL-134. Propose: *J. Theodore Bent* (person); *Gertrude Caton-Thompson* (person); *Peter Garlake* (person); *Rhodesian censorship of Great Zimbabwe archaeology (1970s)* (event).
- **Case (c):** CIV086, SCH019, STY031. Propose: *Sultan 'Ali al-Mashhadi* (person); *Meisterwerke muhammedanischer Kunst, Munich 1910* (exhibition); *M. S. Dimand, A Handbook of Mohammedan Decorative Arts (1930)* (text).
- **Design studies and critique:** PER474, PER475, MOV052. Propose: *Ahmed Ansari* (person).
- **Record bias:** COM030, OBT164, STY088, PRA002, MKR003.

5. Candidate open objects

Holder	Accession	Object, date	Licence as stated	1970 status	Record
The Met	29.76.1-.3	Vasari, <i>Le Vite...</i> , woodcut illustrations, 1568	isPublicDomain: true	n/a (printed book)	https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/358298
The Met	11.84.2	Page of calligraphy (Sa'di and Hafiz), calligrapher Sultan 'Ali al-Mashhadi, Herat, late 15th century	isPublicDomain: true	n/a (manuscript folio, acquired 1911)	https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/446169
Project Gutenberg	eBook 69067	Bent, <i>The Ruined Cities of Mashonaland</i> (1892; this edition 1895); use the site plan only	"Public domain in the USA" (author died 1897)	n/a	https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/69067
Cleveland	1962.244	Gold weight (abrammuo), geometric, Akan-style artist, 1800s (Atlas link)	CC0	pass: in the museum since 1962; how it left Ghana is not recorded	https://clevelandart.org/art/1962.244
Cleveland	1935.306	Gold weight (abrammuo), antelope, 1800s (Atlas link)	CC0	pass: sold by the Charles Ratton Gallery, Paris, in 1935	https://clevelandart.org/art/1935.306

Not open (counter-example): AIC 1986.1043, Kente wrapper, Asante people, 1901/50, rayon. It is flagged "not public domain", so link out only:
<https://www.artic.edu/artworks/65187>

The Met's search indexes 446169 under "muhammedanischer". Whether it was shown in Munich in 1910 is not verified, so the unit does not claim it.

6. People and credit

- **Named on the record:** Vasari (author); Sultan 'Ali al-Mashhadi (calligrapher); Sa'di and Hafiz (poets); Bent (author); Randall-MacIver, Caton-Thompson, Garlake and Paul Sinclair (archaeologists); Mary Moser and Angelica Kauffman (RA founders); Victor Margolin, Adrian Forty, and the eight authors of the Decolonising Design manifesto.
- **Unnamed, and named plainly as unnamed:** the woodcut cutters of the 1568 *Lives*; the margin painters who remounted the Herat folio in the 16th century; the Shona-speaking builders of Great Zimbabwe; the Akan casters ("Akan-style artist" is the museum's phrase); the Asante weavers of the AIC wrapper.
- **Who the credit leaves out:** guild craftsmen outside the academies; women barred from life classes; non-Muslim makers inside "Islamic art"; the Zimbabwean and African scholars whose work the Rhodesian state suppressed.

7. Visual plan (zero cost)

- **Form 13 (argument card):** text only, plus our own small diagram of the word "civilisation" moving from 1756–57 to 1919 to 1992. No portraits of the judges or of Mirabeau.
- **Form 11 (timeline scrub):** the line and all bands are our own diagram. The record-density strip is our chart of Cleveland API counts, dated.
- **Case (a):** Met 358298, public domain.
- **Case (b):** Bent's site plan (public domain), plus our own map of Great Zimbabwe and the Zimbabwe tradition sites. A site photo may be added only from a Wikimedia Commons file whose licence is confirmed at build (not yet chosen, not verified). No images of the birds.
- **Case (c):** Met 446169, public domain. The Munich 1910 poster and catalogue are link-out only.
- **Atlas links:** Cleveland goldweights (CC0); the AIC kente record, UNESCO, the Mabo judgment and the Dimand handbook as link-outs.
- **Generated images:** none of any historical object, person or place.

8. Success criteria

1. The learner rewrites at least one period label as "X, as defined by Y (date)", with a real source.
2. The learner's annotation names at least two world chapters absent from the line, and one thing the record cannot show.
3. The learner writes one sentence that separates adding cases to a timeline from changing how it is framed, using their own annotation as the example.

9. Readings and risks

Pack v2, the Historian pre-read, should check:

- the 1756/1757 date against Benveniste's 1954 essay on the word;
- the 1919 quotation and Brennan J's reply against the official AustLII or High Court text;
- Toynbee's count of civilisations (21 versus "some two dozen"), which changed across his volumes;
- a fair summary of the criticism of Graeber and Wengrow;
- Blair and Bloom against at least one response to them;
- Margolin's 1992 article and Forty's 1993 reply, read in the original.

Hold these steps until a reader clears them:

- the Mabo content (a First Nations reader);
- any Great Zimbabwe image (a Zimbabwean heritage reader, on the birds and the 2026 return);
- the kente and goldweight Atlas cards (an Asante or Ghanaian reader).

The Mirror must not tell learners their assumptions are wrong. It only shows them. Watch its "exclusion" prompts for tokenism.

10. Fact-check list

- Mirabeau's first use: 1756 or 1757, and the exact phrase and its context in *L'Ami des hommes*.
- *In re Southern Rhodesia* [1919] AC 211: the wording, and Brennan J's paragraph numbers in Mabo (No 2) [1992] HCA 23, checked on AustLII.
- Childe (1950), *Town Planning Review* 21: 3–17, and the ten points.
- Toynbee's count of civilisations. Huntington: the 1993 *Foreign Affairs* article and the 1996 book.
- The Graeber and Wengrow wording, confirmed with a page reference from the book.
- Thomsen (1836) and when the museum was first arranged by his scheme (the Rundetaarn article says uncertain).
- The first edition of Vasari (1550). Met 358298 and 446169: public-domain status rechecked.
- Accademia 1563; Académie 1648; Salon first held 1667 and regular from 1737 (GAP084, not opened here); RA 1768 and its 1936 date.

- Canon rows used: POL015 (R1) and PRD070 (R1); CIV005 and CIV086 (R2). Confirm PRD070's claim that metals arrived "in other orders" by region, with an example.
- Bent's quotation and the plan plate number. Randall-MacIver 1906 and Caton-Thompson 1929/1931, from the originals. Garlake's 1970 departure (De Baets).
- The Munich 1910 figures; the Dimand 1930 title.
- The Cleveland counts, rerun on the build date. The Met count behind "strong on the Islamic world".
- AIC 65187: accession 1986.1043, "not public domain". UNESCO 19.COM 7.B.38: State Party Ghana, December 2024.
- Living people: David Wengrow, Adrian Forty, Ahmed Ansari and the other manifesto authors, Paul Sinclair. Check their names, affiliations and publication dates.
- Endonyms: Asanteforo (COM030); Dzimba-dza-mabwe (CIV005); Meriam (Mabo).